phenomenon: a self-perpetuating elite of intellectuals who came up with speculations about time and the cosmos that were centuries ahead of any such thinking elsewhere. At some early point in their history this minority priestly elite had the good sense to form an alliance with a group of warriors to whom they gave good advice in return for their protection. There is a hint, in allusions to an epic struggle between the Brahmins and the Kshatriya warrior caste that ended with the destruction of all the latter, that in their rise to pre-eminence the Brahmins had to fight for survival. The outcome was the formation of a Brahmin–Kshatriya alliance, an axis of thinkers and warriors, that gave these two parties such an advantage that it survived almost intact right up to the twentieth century.

Quite apart from their religious duties, the intellectual and political skills of the Brahmins served generations of rulers extremely well, including foreign rulers just as much as native Rajputs, so much so that a British official writing in the 1870s could feel moved to describe the Brahmins he worked with in the Madras Presidency as ‘so much more intelligent, learned, supple and pleasant to deal with than the common people that almost all writers [on India] have confined themselves to Brahminical life and have led people to imagine that India is what Brahmins are’.[27]